As India’s profile rises, its policymakers are also discovering that expectations of other nations are not confined to our immediate vicinity. Ever since its independence triggered global decolonization, India has carried the responsibility of speaking for a larger constituency. The Global South watches its positions and performance carefully, drawing conclusions from both. In the early days, these were centred on consolidating independence and rebuilding the economy. With the passage of time, more issues of greater complexity have come to occupy the agenda.

The Covid pandemic was the most recent of these, highlighting the challenges of accessibility and affordability of vaccines. Climate action has been a more long-standing concern, with the consistent evasion of financial commitments by the developed countries. The non-tariff barriers on trade and the various forms of protectionism using non-trade considerations are an even longer struggle. Obviously, on many of these issues, India has its own interests at play. But, as it demonstrated through the Vaccine Maitri initiative, it was willing to assist others even in the midst of its own challenges. It was this timing that much of the world recognized as a statement of solidarity. Rebuilding the world order after two centuries of colonialism will not be easy. But India matters because a large part of the Global South believes that it is there for them.

In the last decade, a long tradition of South–South cooperation has developed into something deeper. It captures domains where Indian capabilities have a direct relevance for the aspirations of Africa, Latin America and even the rest of Asia. Some of that has taken the form of development projects in energy, digital, manufacturing, education and connectivity. That has been supported by exchanges of experiences and best practices, including training. It is not just the immediate benefits of these endeavours that matter. They help create more options for the Global South, giving them the leverage to deal with the rest of the world on stronger terms.

On assuming the G20 presidency, the effort at ascertaining the views of 125 nations through the Voice of the Global South Summit was also an initiative that spoke volumes of our mindset. Admittedly, India has an emotional connect with these nations. Whether it is the rise of Africa or the sustainable growth of least developed countries (LDCs), the resulting rebalancing is very much to India’s strategic advantage.